iSWIM

# THE VISIT

*Friedrich Dürrenmatt*

## Issues of Significance

Open-Ended Discussion Questions

# 1 JUSTICE AND ITS SHELF LIFE

i + S

*Can a wrong committed decades ago still demand consequences today – even if the person who committed it has lived an otherwise unremarkable, law-abiding life since?*

**DISCUSSION**

At what point, if any, does time neutralise a moral debt?

Who gets to decide when that point has been reached – the person who was wronged, the person who did wrong, or the community around them?

Does the severity of the original wrong affect how long the debt persists?

# 2 POVERTY AND PRINCIPLE

i + S + W

*When people say they would never compromise their values for money, they are almost always saying it from a position of relative comfort.*

**DISCUSSION**

Is moral conviction a luxury that requires material security to sustain?

If morality depends on circumstances, is it truly morality – or merely a behaviour pattern that appears when conditions allow?

What does this reveal about the nature of “good people”?

# 3 DEMOCRATIC PROCESS AND MORAL OUTCOMES

W + I + M

*If a community votes unanimously and through proper democratic procedure to do something that is clearly wrong, is the outcome legitimate?*

**DISCUSSION**

Can a process be democratic and immoral at the same time?

What does it mean when the machinery of civilisation – voting, consensus, public deliberation – produces barbarism?

Does democratic legitimacy require moral content, or is it purely procedural?

# 4 JUSTICE VERSUS REVENGE

W + M

*We tend to treat justice and revenge as fundamentally different things: justice is legitimate, principled, and institutional; revenge is personal, emotional, and illegitimate.*

**DISCUSSION**

What happens when institutions fail – when the legal system cannot deliver accountability?

Does the injured party then have a right to pursue their own version of justice?

At what point does their pursuit stop being justice and start being something else?

# 5 COLLECTIVE GUILT AND INDIVIDUAL RESPONSIBILI

S + W + M

*When an entire community participates in a harmful act, who is guilty?*

**DISCUSSION**

Everyone equally? The person who proposed it? The person who simply did not object?

Is collective action a way of distributing responsibility, or dissolving it – ensuring no single person feels the full weight of what was done?

How does the language of “community decision” transform the moral character of an act?

# 6 THE PRICE OF PROSPERITY

i + S + M

*Most societies are built, to some degree, on historical wrongs – dispossession, exploitation, violence that created the conditions for present-day comfort.*

**DISCUSSION**

If prosperity has an ugly origin, does that make the prosperity itself tainted?

If we benefit from wrongs we did not personally commit, are we nevertheless complicit?

What would it cost to refuse the benefit – and is anyone genuinely willing to pay?